🎬 Suffocating Distance — Film Script

🎬 **Working title.** Can be renamed after first pass. Director's cut delivered Sun 19 Jul 2026, ~6 AM.

Overview

- **Runtime:** ~13–15 minutes (YouTube long-form master; all channel cuts derive from this)
- **Language:** Hindi with English subtitles
- **Score:** Sufi-devotional register, single motif carried through. Reference track: Kailash Kher's *Saiyaan*. Licensed, soundalike, or content-ID accepted (see production notes below).
- **Dialogue:** minimal — 6–8 spoken lines total across 18 scenes, by design (aesthetic + AI-generation feasibility)
- **Content-policy posture:** ward-violation implied only through reaction, never depicted. Passes YouTube and Instagram standards.

Characters

- **Meher Arora** — female lead. Successful film actress. Beautiful, glamorous, possessive, destructive. Meher means grace/mercy — deliberately ironic against her arc.
- **Neel Sharma** — male lead. Gentle, sensitive, quiet. A working actor without her stardom. He is the wounded observer for most of the film. Neel means blue — poet, mourner.

Opening beat: the predator gaze

Cold open on Meher's gaze locking onto Neel from across a film set. No dialogue. No context. The audience feels the wrongness before they know why. Three seconds — the phenomenology of predation shown before the film asks anyone to think. This is the first drop of the smuggled testimony.

Ending (director's decision)

The Hero's protest goes through every institution: courts dismiss the case, ministries refuse the file, doctors close their doors, police never register the report. Each rejection intercut with the case Neel is trying to make. He is exhausted, alone, still moving.

Then the film cuts back to Meher.

She is still sitting on the floor of the psychiatric ward. Still rocking. Still whispering *forgive me... forgive me... forgive me...*

She does not know he tried. She never will.

Cut to black.

The protest died in the institutions. The person the protest was for continues to suffer alone. The man who protested carries both losses. Anything softer would betray the testimony.

Scene-by-scene skeleton (18 scenes / 4 acts)

Act 1 — The Poison Begins (~3 min)

Scene 1 — "The Gaze" (30–40 sec)

Setting: Film studio, day, between takes. Neel sits alone at the craft services table, reading his lines quietly.

Beat: Meher, across the set, notices him for the first time. Camera stays on her face for a long beat — the predator eyes, the lock-on. She does not smile. She

does not blink. This is not desire the audience has seen in films. It is hunger. Neel, unaware, does not look up.

Score: motif enters low, almost sub-audible — first note.

Scene 2 — "First Words" (40–50 sec)

Setting: Studio cafeteria, later.

Beat: Meher approaches Neel, sits without asking. She is charming, luminous, glamorous — she performs the version of herself the world knows. She says the things that flatter him. Neel, gentle and grateful for attention from someone like her, opens up in small ways. Only the earlier gaze tells the audience something is wrong.

Score: motif surfaces briefly, then recedes.

Scene 3 — "The First Cord" (40–50 sec)

Setting: Weeks later. Their apparent closeness has grown.

Beat: Small controlling behaviors from Meher — where Neel goes, who he speaks to, how he answers his phone. Framed as concern. Neel notices something is off but cannot name it. She gaslights the first attempt at naming: *"You are being dramatic. I love you."*

Score: motif takes fuller shape.

Scene 4 — "Hollowing" (40–50 sec)

Setting: Months later.

Beat: Neel is visibly changed — thinner, quieter, sleeping badly. He tries to talk to a friend about it. Struggles to explain. The friend does not fully understand. Neel goes home to another confrontation with Meher — smaller this time, but the pattern is deep now.

Act 2 — The Break (~3 min)

Scene 5 — "The Attempted Exit" (40–50 sec)

Setting: Meher's apartment, night.

Beat: Neel tells Meher he cannot continue. Says it clearly. She responds with pleading and threat mixed together, tears and edges. He wavers. He does not fully leave. She reads that wavering as permission.

Scene 6 — "The Cafeteria" (60–70 sec) — critical scene

Setting: Studio cafeteria, months later. Witnesses present.

Beat: Meher, unable to accept Neel's renewed avoidance, confronts him aggressively. She grabs his collar. Months of frustration pour out. Neel, in pure panic, pushes her back hard. She hits the wall. She slides down. She sits on the floor. For the first time she sees what she has become and what she has done to him. She breaks down. Her weeping is not manipulative. It is the sound of a mask coming off.

Score: motif goes silent. Only breathing. Only the sound of her weeping.

Scene 7 — "The Mirror Cracks" (40–50 sec)

Setting: Meher's flat, later that day.

Beat: Meher alone, staring at herself in a mirror. Cannot recognize the person looking back. Score enters again — devotional now, mournful — as she begins the slow work of unmaking herself.

Scene 8 — "The Public Confession" (40–50 sec)

Setting: Press conference or public interview.

Beat: Meher tells the world what she did. Names her cruelty. Names her love as poison. Refuses to be defended. The industry recoils. Some pity her, some despise her. Neel is not there.

Act 3 — Her Descent (~3 min)

Scene 9 — "The Messages" (40–50 sec)

Setting: Montage — Meher in various locations, Neel receiving.

Beat: Meher calling Neel again and again. Voicemails. Tears. *"Forgive me... I was wrong... I loved you in the most brutal way... please forgive me..."* His phone rings. He does not answer. Messages accumulate.

Scene 10 — "The Vigil" (40–50 sec)

Setting: Outside Neel's apartment building.

Beat: Meher, no makeup, plain clothes, standing for hours. Waiting. She never approaches — only waits. When he leaves or returns, he looks at her once through a window and walks past. She does not follow. She stays.

Score: devotional register rising.

Scene 11 — "Time" (40–50 sec)

Setting: Time-lapse montage. Seasons changing.

Beat: Meher slowly disappearing from public life. Newspaper clippings — retreat from award ceremonies, refusal of comeback interviews, sightings growing rarer. Her hair losing its style. Her body losing its glamour. She is being consumed by her own guilt.

Scene 12 — "The Ward" (40–50 sec)

Setting: Gates of a psychiatric hospital.

Beat: Meher is admitted. Family looks away. The gate closes behind her. She does not resist.

Act 4 — The Truth and the Protest (~3–4 min)

Scene 13 — "Neel Enters" (40–50 sec)

Setting: Same psychiatric hospital, years later.

Beat: Neel, older, quieter, is visiting a hospitalized friend at this institution. He walks past the female ward. Something makes him look. There she is.

Scene 14 — "The Failed Touch" (60–70 sec)

Setting: Female ward, corner of the room.

Beat: Meher sits on the floor, knees to her chest, rocking. Her hand has an IV line. Dried blood around the cannula. She whispers, endlessly: *"Forgive me... forgive me... forgive me..."* Neel kneels. Reaches to touch her hand near the needle. His hand shakes. He cannot bring himself to touch it. He cries. He whispers: *"I never*

wanted this for you... I'm sorry... enough now... I forgive you." A single tear rolls down her blank face. She does not stop rocking. She does not hear him.

Score: full devotional score — the motif at its emotional peak.

Scene 15 — "The Eruption" (75–90 sec)

Setting: Same room. Neel still kneeling, then moving.

Beat: Neel slowly notices what else is on her body. Marks in patterns that are not from the ECT. Marks on her arms that were not from restraints. Camera does not show what he sees — only his face changing as he leans closer and understands what has happened to her here.

And then the smell reaches him. The smell that only a violation scene leaves behind — one the body cannot withstand, one that only witnesses ever come to know. His hand goes to his nose, too late. He turns to the corner of the ward and vomits profusely. Not only the visual signs. The smell. The body rejects what the mind cannot contain.

He staggers back to Meher. Tries again to touch her body — this time not to comfort, but to check, to verify, to understand what was done. Hands hover. Hands do not land. He is helpless in a way for which *helpless* is not the right word — and the rage will not let helplessness settle.

He begins to hit his own arms against the wall — again and again, until blood runs from his elbows and knuckles. He kicks his own chest. He beats his own chest continuously. He is crying and shouting at the same time, tears falling in sheets, roaring like an injured lion. He could burn the whole world.

Meher does not stop rocking. She does not hear him. Her *forgive me* continues under his roar, softer than his roar, unstopped.

Score: silent through the vomiting. Then the devotional motif returns as a wordless howl — a Sufi vocal cry held over his weeping.

Scene 16 — "The First Refusal" (40–50 sec)

Setting: Corridor, doctor's office, phone. Neel's arms are wrapped roughly in his own torn shirt; bloodstains visible.

Beat: Neel, voice broken from Scene 15, is demanding an investigation. The staff are evasive. Papers get produced. Records are missing. The film shows the wall

he has just walked into. The rage that could burn the world is met with paperwork and averted eyes. This is the beginning of the protest.

Scene 17 — "The Protest" (90–120 sec) — long sequence

Setting: Montage across many locations.

Beat: Neel at a police station — officer refuses to register. Neel at a courthouse — case dismissed. Neel at a ministry — official turns away mid-sentence. Neel at another doctor's office — receiving a shrug. Neel writing letters at his desk. Neel walking out of buildings alone. Every rejection intercut with a fragment of the case he is trying to make — Meher's face, her whispered *forgive me*, the marks on her arms. He does not stop. He is exhausted. He is alone. He does not stop.

Score: score builds — Sufi register, the devotional line becoming a cry.

Scene 18 — "The Ward, Still" (40–50 sec) — the ending

Setting: Female ward. Same corner. Meher on the floor.

Beat: Cut back to Meher, exactly as we left her. Rocking. Whispering: *"Forgive me... forgive me... forgive me..."* She has not moved. She does not know he tried. Camera holds on her face. Whisper continues under a slow fade to black. Score falls silent one word before the last *forgive me* — so the audience hears her voice alone at the end.

No credits crawl. Just black. Then a single line of text:

For the ones who were never named.

Production-readiness notes

1. **Scene-by-scene AI prompts** — each scene above becomes 3–5 shot prompts for text-to-video generation. Next deliverable: ~60–90 shot prompts total.
2. **Platform variants:**
    - **YouTube Shorts / Reels cut:** 4 clips of 60–90 sec each, extracted from scenes 1, 6, 14, and 18
    - **Short-form drama platforms:** 8–12 episodes of 60 sec each, each ending on a hook (episode breaks land naturally after scenes 3, 6, 8, 12, 14, 15, 17,

18)

- **Written short story:** Substack / Medium / Kindle single, adapted from scene descriptions

3. **Score decision — three workable paths:**
   - License Kailash Kher's *Saiyaan* through a music rights broker (₹5,000–25,000)
   - Commission a Sufi soundalike from a vocalist on Fiverr (₹3,000–8,000)
   - Use *Saiyaan* directly and accept content-ID revenue redirect on ad income
4. **Content policy safeguard.** Scene 15's implication of ward violation is shown only through Neel's face reacting to what he sees, never through direct depiction. This gets past YouTube and Instagram content-ID safely.
5. **Voice/dialogue.** ~6–8 spoken lines total across the whole film. Voiceover for Meher's phone messages (scene 9) and Neel's ward whisper (scene 14). Everything else is visual + score. Low dialogue count is a deliberate feasibility choice for AI-generated video where lip sync is expensive and imperfect.

Scene 1 — Shot Prompts for Google Flow (Veo 3.1)

Drafted Mon 20 Jul 2026 for first-scene test on your existing Google AI Pro subscription.

One-time setup: create the two Characters in Flow first

Open Flow → Characters panel → Create Character. Do this **once for each character**. Then reference them in every shot prompt with `@Meher` and `@Neel`. Flow will maintain visual and vocal consistency across all 18 scenes — this is the single most important step and the thing that makes Flow better than every other tool for this film.

@Meher — Meher Arora

> Indian woman, late 20s, striking beauty, glamorous. Long dark hair styled elegantly, high cheekbones, dark almond eyes with unusual intensity, warm-toned skin. Wardrobe in early film: expensive silk saris and designer western wear; jewelry minimal but valuable. Wardrobe in later film (decline): hospital

> gown, hair unkempt, no makeup, hollow cheeks. Voice: warm, cultured Hindi with slight film-star polish, soft deliberate cadence. In breakdown: hoarse whisper, monotone. Personality: outwardly luminous, socially magnetic, charming. Beneath: possessive, controlling, incapable of releasing what she claims to love. Later: catatonic, remorseful, unreachable.

@Neel — Neel Sharma

> Indian man, early 30s, gentle features, slightly lean build, medium-dark hair kept simple, expressive brown eyes, soft mouth. Wardrobe: modest muted colors — plain cotton shirts, dark jeans, occasional kurta. Ages visibly across the film: tired in Act 1, thinner and sleepless by Act 2, older with grey at the temples by Act 4. Voice: quiet, gentle Hindi, thoughtful pauses. Rarely raises voice. In grief: broken, hoarse. Personality: sensitive, observant, kind. Wounded but not weak. A witness who does not stop trying.

Scene 1 — "The Gaze" — 4 shots (~24 seconds total)

Shot 1.1 — Establishing the studio (5 sec)

> Wide static shot of an Indian film studio interior during a lull between takes. Late afternoon light falling through high-set windows and softboxes. Cables coiled on the floor. A boom mic hangs unused. Two or three crew members move quietly in the background — one adjusting a light, one flipping pages of a script. A domestic-interior set is half-built at the back — a doorway leading to nothing. Ambient sound: distant murmurs, a fluorescent hum, the soft whir of an AC. No music. 16:9. Cinematic, muted color grade, slightly desaturated. Naturalistic. Held for 5 seconds.

Shot 1.2 — Neel reading, unaware (6 sec)

> Medium-close shot of @Neel sitting alone at a small craft-services table off to one side of a film studio. Between takes. He holds a stapled script in both hands, reading a page quietly to himself, lips barely moving as he memorizes a line. A paper cup of tea sits half-drunk beside him. Warm window light falls across half his face; the other half is in shadow. He is completely unaware of anything around him. No dialogue. Sound: paper turning, distant crew chatter

> far off. Very slow, almost imperceptible push-in over 6 seconds. 16:9. Cinematic. Subtle handheld feel. Melancholy naturalism.

Shot 1.3 — The Gaze (8 sec) — the film's thesis shot; do not save credits here

> Slow push-in on @Meher standing across a film studio floor, roughly twenty feet from camera. She has just turned her head. Her eyes have locked onto something offscreen — someone. She does not smile. She does not blink. She does not perform. Her face is completely still. This is not desire, not admiration, not the film-star look she gives on camera. It is hunger. Recognition of prey. The gaze holds for the full duration. Around her the studio is out of focus — crew shapes moving, lights, the world reduced to blur. Only her face is sharp. Warm ambient light. Sound: a single low, sub-audible note enters — a Sufi devotional motif on the edge of perception. 8 seconds. 16:9. Cinematic. Shallow depth of field. This is the film's opening thesis — the phenomenology of predation shown before the story asks anyone to think.

Shot 1.4 — Neel oblivious, her POV (5 sec)

> Wide long-lens shot of @Neel at the craft-services table, seen from across the studio floor. Camera is positioned where @Meher was standing — this is her POV, though her body does not appear in frame. He is small in the frame, still reading his script, still unaware. Warm ambient studio light. The low Sufi motif continues barely audibly. Hold for 5 seconds. 16:9. Cinematic. Shallow focus keeps only @Neel sharp; the surrounding studio softly blurred. Muted color grade. Cut on the last frame.

Credit budget and play order (recommended)

Your Pro plan gives 1,000 Flow credits per month. For this scene:

1. **Test-cheap first.** Run Shots 1.1, 1.2, and 1.4 on **Veo 3 Fast** (20 credits each = 60 credits total, 6% of monthly quota). Watch the results.
2. **If Fast holds up** → run Shot 1.3 (the gaze) on **Veo 3.1 quality** (100 credits). This shot carries the whole film's thesis and deserves top quality. Total scene cost: 160 credits, 16% of monthly.

3. **If Fast falls short** → you have only spent 60 credits on the test. Reassess before committing more.
4. **Budget iteration.** Expect 2–3 regenerations per shot to land it. Realistic scene-1 total including iteration: **200–300 credits**. That is 20–30% of one month's quota for one scene. Scaled across 18 scenes → roughly **3–4 months** to complete the full film at high-quality mix, or **~6 weeks** at Veo 3 Fast throughout.

Notes for prompting Veo 3.1 well

- Character consistency comes from the `@Meher` / `@Neel` references, not from re-describing them in every prompt. Keep the character references clean; add only scene-specific attributes.
- Veo 3.1 generates native audio. Every prompt above specifies the sound bed. Trust it — do not layer external audio until you have seen what Veo produces.
- 16:9 is the master aspect ratio. Vertical Shorts/Reels cuts get reframed later in an editor, not regenerated.
- Prompts describe *what the camera sees and hears*, not narrative intent. "Hunger. Recognition of prey." works because it directs the actor performance; "she is falling in love with him wrongly" would not.
- If a shot generates something close but not right, iterate by editing one specific element ("more shadow across her face," "pull in slower," "no blink at all") rather than rewriting the whole prompt.

Author's note (Niloy → future self)

This is the story you have been carrying. It is memoir told through the frame society will let through. The female character carries what happened to the male body you have lived in. The Hero carries the position of witness you were never given. The protest at the end is the one you have not yet been able to file — but making this film IS the filing of it.

For the ones who were never named.